

Generative Dreams: Rethinking GenAI Design Through a Community-based Approach with Recently Incarcerated, Gang Affiliated, and At-risk Young Adults at a Trauma Informed Arts Center

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Figure 1: 1-Two Google researchers guide the HBAA workshop group on creating a zine using a piece of letter-size paper. 2-Presents a completed zine page featuring a more polished version of students' project idea, developed post-workshop. 3. Students exploring GenAI tools. 4-Google researcher assisting student after workshop with website activity.

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Abstract

This paper presents a case study of a community-based participatory design approach to exploring generative AI at a trauma-informed arts center. Through a week-long workshop engagement between Google, UC Irvine, and Homeboy Art Academy, the study investigates how centering marginalized voices can improve AI development and address equity issues. Key findings highlight the importance of insider relationships in building trust, respecting

community resourcefulness, and fostering bidirectional relationships. By integrating diverse perspectives early in the development process, this approach aims to create more inclusive and effective AI technologies. The study contributes to our understanding of community-based participatory AI design and offers strategies for responsible engagement with underserved populations in emerging technology development.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **HCI theory, concepts and models.**

Keywords

Community-Based Participatory Design, GenAI, Co-Design, Design Methodologies, Diverse Populations

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1 INTRODUCTION

In this case study, an industry-academic-community partnership uses Community-Based Participatory Design (CBPD) methods to explore novel approaches to the design of Generative AI (GenAI) tools. Treating GenAI as a general purpose tool reveals the limitations of traditional User Experience (UX) methods, which are more suitable for designing single-purpose tech applications. There is an urgent need to explore alternative forms of design engagement with communities historically excluded from technology design because GenAI is already impacting fundamental social structures [4, 49, 54, 69]. This impact is especially felt in marginalized communities such as judicial-system impacted, gang affiliated, and or at risk young adults, who are rarely considered equal partners in HCI and technology design [43]. CPBD is more suitable for designing general-purpose tech, because it focuses on marginalized perspectives that more accurately reflect societal complexity. A shift away from “traditional” user archetypes ensures designs are based on a much wider representation of users [7, 23, 42, 55].

AI product development rarely involves historically excluded communities [31, 60, 66]. The increased deployment of GenAI raises societal concerns, including the potential displacement of skilled labor, risks of algorithmically-powered cultural erasure and unfair decision-making [26, 52]. Equally important is the positive case for empowering marginalized people to use GenAI, where they can understand, use, and deploy GenAI tools to address everyday needs [56]. If AI becomes fundamental infrastructure, similar to critical utilities like water or electricity [16, 57] the need for equitable GenAI becomes imperative—but so too, does a democratically-oriented design practice. By expanding who is involved in its design, we can both reduce economic and socio-cultural harms that result from exclusive development within the vacuum of exclusive tech labs and increase access to the benefits of AI. CBPD

can preempt the digital divide from growing into an “AI divide” [18, 20, 22, 24, 26, 32, 48, 62]. From a business perspective, creating tools that are more than novelties for tech elites—tools that address the needs of underserved communities, will increase the market reach of these tools beyond WEIRD (Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic) populations [36].

This paper contributes to our understanding of GenAI and CBPD by: (1) Describing how working directly with marginalized populations within their contexts instead of the usability lab can improve the quality of GenAI; (2) Exploring the specific lived realities of marginalized populations affecting the adoption of GenAI; (3) Revealing limitations in culturally constructed notions of “expertise” that discourage the full use of GenAI by general populations; (4) Suggesting limitations in traditional UX practices for designing and evaluating generative AI tools. We hypothesize that for better, fairer GenAI tools—those that society truly needs—community-focused co-design engagements are required. What follows is a summary of what we did and what we learned from one community engagement. We are not offering this as a prescription for a curriculum so much as a set of learnings about a methodology for community engagement.

2 CASE CONTEXT

2.1 Local Context and Community Partnership

We explored the hypotheses outlined above during an intensive week-long workshop that took place over five consecutive days, at the HBAA in Boyle Heights, East Los Angeles. A team of six researchers and designers (academic and industry) approached this engagement guided by the following research questions: (1) In what ways can expanding the definition of “expertise” to include lived experiences and community knowledge contribute to the development of AI that addresses a broader range of societal needs?; (2) How effective is a community-based participatory design approach in uncovering insights about AI’s potential uses for both personal and community-level challenges?; (3) How does the involvement of traditionally under-served communities in AI design processes reveal specific limitations and biases in existing GenAI tools, and what measurable impacts does this involvement have on tool functionality and accessibility?

Our research partnership involved three parties: 1) the Homeboy Industries Art Academy (HBAA), 2) Researchers at UC Irvine (UCI), and 3) a research and design group at Google named the Envisioning Studio within the Technology and Society organization. We grounded our work in the firsthand experience and relationships developed by the academic partners who have an ongoing 4-year engagement with Homeboy Art Academy and deep personal and cultural connections with this community [43]. Our intent with this engagement was to explore pathways between high-tech industry partners and community-based organizations to elicit perspectives on how GenAI tools can be used by people not already embedded in the tech world and witness, first-hand, the limitations of these tools in real-world contexts. Further, we were motivated to explore methodological approaches that can help provide the perspectives of marginalized voices in the design and evaluation of GenAI tools and thereby expand the relevance and impact of these tools to more people.

HBAA is a division under a larger non-profit gang rehabilitation and re-entry organization, Homeboy Industries, located East of Los Angeles, in the community of Boyle Heights. Established in 1988 by Father Greg Boyle, Homeboy Industries provides wrap-around social services (therapy, GED tutoring, tattoo removal) and employment opportunities via social enterprises including a bakery, screen printing, recycling plant, and cafe [8]. The legacy of historically discriminatory policies - including the forced internment of Japanese families during the 1940s and racially biased redlining practices - coupled with an influx of laborers brought about by World War II workforce initiatives like the Bracero Program shaped the demographics and challenges faced by neighborhood residents. Entrenched poverty, gang violence, drug abuse, and police brutality impact educational opportunities in the community [19, 47, 61].

2.2 Rationale for Using Community-Based Workshops and Research Goals

Participatory Design (PD) is a method that emerged in Scandinavia through research partnerships between academics and trade unions in the 1970s [13]. As computer systems transformed the workplace, this new methodology emerged to give workers a voice in technological decisions affecting their jobs. CBPD extends traditional Participatory Design by emphasizing localized social action research, where design interventions are tailored to address needs specifically identified by community members [33, 43, 63–65]. While more common in healthcare informatics, researchers are increasingly utilizing CBPD approaches to construct more equitable AI technologies [34, 37, 41, 53].

Our hope is to see CBPD become a standard methodology for building GenAI tools and infrastructure. Although not a panacea, CBPD may be a step towards creating better, more equitable, tools—not just in response to harms such tools can cause working-class communities of color [17, 46], but because a community-based approach to GenAI design could lead to more relevant, beneficial and widely adopted AI tools. As AI, the "tool of tools," becomes the foundational computing infrastructure for intelligent applications, similar to how water and power are public utilities, it is essential to include expert input from outside traditional high-tech networks, particularly from marginalized communities [4, 16]. We sought to shift focus from the expertise of, say, career professionals or knowledge-workers, and to highlight non-traditional modes of intelligence rooted in a particular community's capacity to adjust to changing circumstances and find creative solutions in the face of economic uncertainty and other forms of adversity. Engaging communities, like HBAA's Art Gang, can help designers and developers think broadly about use cases for GenAI that are more applicable to everyday life and potentially more transformative.

Methodologically, our workshop prioritized practical activities to provide a foundation for deeper conceptual discussions about AI. This study employs case study techniques [59] to characterize the nature of emerging interactions. Each workshop session was recorded with three cameras, which were operated by a film crew. Eight HBAA students were interviewed upon completion of the workshop and 25 students attended the workshops at least once. These notes were combined into this case narrative, with an emphasis on events pertaining to research questions. Consistent with Stake

(1995), findings should be regarded as petite generalizations, which have experience-near significant, and experience-distant relevance. The goal, from this pragmatic orientation to knowledge, is to create knowledge credible to local stakeholders and of potential value to academics, industry, or other communities of practice, rather than immutable truth [29]. All names used in the below sections are pseudonyms used to protect the identity of our participants. This study aligns with activities approved under the University's Institutional Review Board (IRB) as part of a broader ongoing research initiative at the academy.

3 GETTING READY & THE CURRICULUM

3.1 Preparation

The planning, organization, and implementation of this case study spanned six months, from January through July 2024. The cross-institutional team held bimonthly meetings and shared plans weekly with HBAA students to gather feedback and form alignment across stakeholders [51].

Google researchers joined for daily "check-in" circles via video chat several times prior to the in-person, August workshop. Check-ins are a ritualistic practice occurring at the start of each day. Students sit in a circular formation, facing each other. Sage is burned (an indigenous practice to ward off negative energies) and individuals rate their mood on a scale of 1-10. Participants are asked a reflection question, such as, "What is something you know now that you wish a younger version of yourself could have known?" Sharing reflections and insights provides practice connecting with emotions, sympathizing with others, and forming a community. Participants can "pass" on the practice, but otherwise the ritual requires vulnerability as titles, social positions, and status are dropped. It was the perfect context for Google to begin joining this community and for trust to form across groups.

3.2 The Curriculum: Overview of Workshop Activities

Workshop activities centered around two constructs: generating chapters for a 'zine' (a grassroots, small-circulated self-published work - traditionally reproduced via a copy machine [44]) and enabling students to start envisioning AI applications that could help them address an individual or collective challenges. Crafting of a digital 'zine was meant to help align the workshop around a shared end goal. Each student would share, 1) their experiences using GenAI, 2) challenges they encountered, and 3) opportunities they saw for its use in their own chapter of the 'zine. This approach scaffolded student learning about new generative AI tools and concepts - an educational technique aimed at providing interim structure while breaking down larger ideas into smaller parts accompanied by multiple means of content representations [14].

This approach was suggested by our university partner because Art Gang students can have undiagnosed learning needs as a result of being neglected in traditional educational settings [2, 3, 10, 27, 28]. Many educational institutions are not designed to support students who endure traumas, such as drug-addicted parents, poverty, abuse, and incarceration. Many HBAA students joined gangs earlier in their lives seeking refuge from these traumas [9]. Within traditional classroom settings, these students may feel ostracized and rejected

because of their gang affiliation which limits their learning opportunities. Thus, our workshop used a scaffolded, experiential approach to help students explore and critically engage with GenAI tools.

Beginning with playful exercises in Google's AI Test Kitchen, we introduced consumer-grade AI functionalities through hands-on activities grounded in real-world scenarios. Google introduced AI Test Kitchen to allow people to learn about, experience, and give feedback on emerging GenAI technology, and demonstrate the power of its foundational model, Gemini. Our workshop made this relevant to the Art Gangs' interests. For example, students used the test Kitchen's ImageFX to create brand materials for a hypothetical pop-up store and MusicFX to generate audio for a streetwear brand's social media campaign. We also demonstrated Gemini's file and image analysis features through practical scenarios, such as navigating the legal complexities of an apartment rental agreement or navigating a menu written in Japanese.

In our efforts to push boundaries, we attempted a web page creation exercise using Gemini. This multi-step task involved generating code from visual descriptions, testing it in an online editor, and publishing the results. It required switching between multiple applications, a clunkiness that decreased engagement. This experience provided valuable insights into the challenges of implementing advanced technical concepts within our specific context. It revealed deficiencies in the tools that otherwise would have been obfuscated in more traditional UXR engagements. For GenAI tools to be adopted by the general public they will need integrated applications involving fewer steps.

As the week progressed, we recognized the value of grounding students' reflections in concrete experiences. Rather than soliciting abstract ideas, we guided students through increasingly complex exercises, from applying GenAI in their existing work at the academy to envisioning net-new AI tools for personal or community challenges. This stair-step approach allowed students to gradually build their understanding of AI's potential applications in their lives rather than focusing on "blue sky" thinking which potentially can ostracize participants [35]. Workshop activities were often adjusted to better suit student needs and to create a more exploratory learning environment. Our adaptive, hands-on approach ultimately empowered students to envision how GenAI could serve their needs and consider its broader, theoretical implications.

4 OUTCOMES & LESSONS LEARNED

The following section presents our case narrative and emergent themes. Findings are presented as petite generalizations, generalizations that occur within a case, and may be extended to analogous situations.

4.1 The Social Ground of Sociotechnical Tools

A key focus of the workshop was positioning Gemini as a "tool of tools." Exercises focused on two themes: "AI and Me," in which students explore GenAI tools for solving individual challenges, and "AI and Us," in which students imagine how AI could address challenges that exist in the student's communities. Google researchers desired to explore what Art Academy students wanted to build with Gemini, free of constraints. UCI researchers posited that exploring abstract, speculative applications of generative AI tools

required structured scaffolding. A tension arose between Google's theoretical objectives (e.g., "blue sky" thinking about how students could make practical use of GenAI tools) and the university researcher's experience with practical community engagement (e.g., years of research with this community and growing knowledge of its needs) and their situational-awareness about the need to ground abstract exploration in concrete content and scaffold participant engagement levels.

The UCI researchers learned, from previous projects, to use scenario-based activity as scaffolding for deeper engagement, interest, and self-agency in art academy students. Thus, they suggested keeping exercises concrete, building lessons toward greater abstraction, and working 1-on-1 with students to gain insights into their specific lived experiences. Because the university researchers built an environment of trust, a student participant was willing to reveal a recently traumatic experience with a carjacking. When that student started using the GenAI music tool to create soothing music, the researchers encouraged deeper exploration, speculating that the interest in calming music was rooted in this recent experience. The student subsequently built these initial explorations into a design sketch of a "therapeutic sanctuary" tool powered by AI-generated content. The student's design sought to help those in the community who resist accepting therapeutic interventions (out of shame, fear, cultural or other reasons). His goal was to provide a private AI-assisted means of addressing anxiety and other symptoms related to trauma. From trust-based exchanges like this, the team was able to elicit deeper engagement into personal narratives that resulted in more useful GenAI design ideas.

The primacy of understanding individual, cultural, and communal context cannot be overstated. By centering the lived experiences of regular, everyday people in the design and development of GenAI tech we can avoid some of the problems this technology presents for traditionally underrepresented and marginalized groups [6, 18, 39, 52, 53, 58, 67, 68]. For example, it is widely known, but still no less problematic, that LLM-powered tools continue to generate content that lacks cultural specificity [1, 11, 12, 20, 46]. Out of 715 image generation attempts during the workshop, 25 included the word "Mexican" in the prompts. The outputs were largely generic and stereotypical representations of the Mexican community (brown-skinned characters wearing sombreros or in floral-pattern dresses with braids). Again, stereotypes and a lack of cultural specificity are well-known, persistent issues in LLM-powered image generators [5, 38, 40]. But what's worth noting here is that students responded to these results with casual frustration and amusement rather than outrage. They laughed it off and moved on. This seemingly nonchalant reaction reflects a broader trend among those whose cultural identities are often misrepresented or overlooked by AI models: a sense of resignation, or a prioritization of more immediate concerns. For a community grappling with more pressing issues like resource shortages, threats, trauma, and prejudice, the association of the word "Mexican" with a specific type of hat or other stereotypes doesn't appear to be a significant concern.

Tech companies have a massive opportunity to begin addressing real-world user's self-understanding and identity diversity. With fine-tuning for cultural specificity, there is potential for LLM-interaction to help develop self-efficacy and inspire the student's

own goals and aspirations. For example, when one student input the prompt, “Los Angeles gangster lettering tattoo,” the tool generated intricate tattoo designs that kept the student prompting for more. When these tools reflect the culturally specific interests of the user, they are more engaging and more useful. AI tools should accommodate user’s lived experiences and generate desired outputs. This becomes a question of AI infrastructure: should we expect every tool to include the specificity of every culture, or should we make it easy for communities to fine-tune a model they are using? What if each community could use their own culturally-specific data set, which they maintain control over, to create outputs that are more reflective of their own cultural identity and ethos?

4.2 The Tech in Sociotechnical Tools

Acknowledging the primacy of the social, it also became evident to the Google researchers that existing AI technical infrastructure was inadequate and designed for a different type of user—those already familiar with navigating complex back-end systems. This disconnect was particularly apparent during a Day Two workshop session focused on using Gemini to create an interactive webpage. While many AI applications offer a straightforward input-output mechanism, this exercise revealed the complexities of real-world tasks. To build the webpage, students had to move across multiple tools: Gemini for code generation and review, an online code editor to test the code, and an online code hosting platform to create an instant webpage. The need to switch among multiple tools created technical and social constraints that limited the students’ sense of possibility, highlighting the need for a more integrated and user-friendly infrastructure to support AI-powered solutions for real-world problems.

In this context, students became frustrated with the AI tools for two reasons: 1) the friction of usability issues, and 2) their assumptions that AI would complete a task successfully on its first attempt. When they encountered unexpected errors, inconsistent results, or unclear guidance—as they did with imageFX—it undermined their confidence and sense of agency, causing their enthusiasm to wane. This points to the need for better design around 1) easier to use infrastructure and 2) design affordances and signifiers that help users understand that the best AI outputs result from multiple turns and human-led adjustments. Improving both aspects of AI design will likely increase confidence and engagement and help users more easily achieve their AI-assisted aspirations.

4.3 Lived Experiences as Foundations for GenAI Design

Context plays a crucial role in understanding our methodological choices and the participants’ design ideas. Many participants face educational challenges stemming from various socioeconomic factors and past traumas related to gang affiliations, and police and justice system interactions. Recognizing these challenges, we designed our workshop to create an inclusive, supportive learning environment that diverged from conventional classroom experiences. Students were encouraged to explore how they would use AI, even if it needed redesigning to work as they envisioned. The results were rich and intriguing, often worthy of prototyping. Several

notable examples emerged from this exercise, each highlighting unique perspectives on AI application.

Chloe, with a longstanding interest in filmmaking, focused on GenAI-powered special effects to reduce the need for expensive equipment or specialized production teams. Her icon- and symbol-based UI design, which echoes requests made by industry stakeholders, could potentially democratize access to high-quality filmmaking tools. Another student, Grace, envisioned an AI tool to empower her community by breaking down personal aspirations into achievable steps. She pictured a project-management tool that would generate personalized action plans, adapting to individual circumstances and addressing systemic challenges.

Aiden, experienced in creating and selling streetwear, designed a GenAI tool to assist in translating his design ideas into manufacturable specifications. His personal experience with unaffordable design assistance that failed to match his creative vision inspired his project. Importantly, Aiden recognized the tensions his project raised regarding “authenticity of craft” and potential job displacement for designers. He questioned whether there’s an authenticity of craftsmanship in exercising one’s imagination, noting his ability to envision designs even if he couldn’t draw them himself. This perspective offers valuable insights into the evolving nature of creativity in the age of AI. For Chloe and Aiden, the potential to unlock creative pursuits by eliminating the need for specific skills far outweighs the concern of job displacement. Both Chloe and Aiden were motivated to build businesses in creative industries without significant capital investment, highlighting how AI could lower barriers to entry in these fields.

In a spontaneous application of the workshop’s teachings, one student used Gemini on his phone to write a business and career development plan. He proposed a new “Marketing and Community Relations Navigator” role for himself at the Art Academy, demonstrating how he applied the AI tools to pursue a self-imagined opportunity. This instance underscores the immediate, practical impact of AI literacy on personal and professional development.

These design explorations collectively highlight how AI could democratize access to tools and opportunities traditionally reserved for those with significant resources or specialized training. They also raise important questions about the nature of creativity, authenticity, and the potential impact of AI on various industries. The students’ ideas, rooted in their lived experiences and community needs, offer valuable perspectives on AI development that may be overlooked in more traditional tech environments or through traditional UX methodologies.

5 SUCCESSFUL STRATEGIES FOR COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

Several strategies for community engagement resulted from this case study. Some insights come from what went well, while others were informed by unexpected challenges that required us to adjust our approach. While not conclusive, the strategies do reflect our academic partners’ extensive three-year engagement with our community-based partner. We provide a table summarizing some core strategies for community engagement generalized from this case study in our appendix. What follows is our focus on our most salient insights.

5.1 Insiders Matter

Google's access to the community in this case study was clearly conditioned on our academic partner's long-standing relationship with Homeboy Art Academy. Because the academics at UC Irvine, especially Richard Martinez, have earned the trust of both HBAA leadership and of the community, they were able to transfer some of that trust onto their Google research partners. One example from an early planning call demonstrates this. The call was between Google, UCI, Fabian Debora (the Homeboy Art Academy Director) and an HBAA Board Member. We discussed the ethos of the project, some high-level strategy and even some ideas on how to explore our research intuitions in specific exercises during that call. At several points during the conversation, Fabian and a Board Member gave feedback on the workshop but also deferred to Richard on how to proceed with comments like, "We trust that Richard knows what he is doing," or "If Richard thinks this is the best way to proceed, we agree".

This researcher's relationship with Homeboy has been strengthened by years of doing HCI research there, but it pre-exists his academic research. He was born and raised in Boyle Heights, and has had a longstanding relationship with the Homeboy community. When HBAA leadership came to consider the value of pursuing the project and the specifics on how to proceed, they trusted in its value largely because an insider in their community was willing to endorse the project. Not only was trust built with leadership via this relationship; it also established with the community because of the ways that Richard helped to introduce and integrate the Google researchers into the community.

During the months of prep, Martinez began socializing the idea to individual community members of working with Google researchers. He encouraged the community to see that they would make a novel and important contribution to AI development at Google and that Google researchers were interested in hearing the expert opinions of the community. The first author also began hosting video calls where Google researchers were introduced to the community during a daily community circle session (detailed above). We also shared plans for the workshop and how it would be structured and asked for and received feedback directly from the community on how it should proceed.

Additional practices, like having Richard facilitate large sections of the workshop and help with transitions to other facilitators fostered trust. We also made the collective decision to sit alongside community members and integrate into the exercise during the workshop. Instead of having the facilitators stand at the front of the classroom, or sit separate from the students, we integrated researchers and students sitting side-by-side and talking 1-on-1 throughout exercises. In addition, Google researchers made it a point to stay after the workshop to engage with the HBAA community after the completion of planned activities.

These kinds of strategies were essential for creating authentic bonds for genuine feedback and exploration of ideas. Community engagement work must begin with community insider(s) vouching for the project, and the best way to ensure that is done genuinely is with active involvement from that community insiders throughout the process of designing and executing on the engagement. It is

not real community engagement without sustained and substantive community involvement from the start, led by community members.

5.2 Respect Resourcefulness

Another insight involved the profound resourcefulness and pragmatism of the community. As early as the first day, students were quick to generate outputs with the Image and Music AI generators that they wanted to save and share. There was a spirit of engagement that seemed to stem from a desire to seize the opportunity in front them. An entrepreneurial sensibility was prevalent with some students immediately finding outputs that inspired ideas for business applications (developing a clothing line, building a website) or artistic expression (personalizing tattoo art, creating background music for TikTok clips or video games, etc).

As students warmed up to the researchers, some shared stories about recent trauma or violence they had encountered, or struggles with money and meeting basic necessities. This was done in a matter-of-fact manner, not one that was seeking sympathy or asking for help. It was clear that many students have developed a deep resourcefulness and grit as a matter of survival. And even though participants were willing to give their unvarnished opinions about some of the failings of the tech or where it needed to be improved, there was generally a pragmatic attitude about trying to use it in ways that would be beneficial for them.

The ability to navigate some of life's greatest hardship has built resilience, self-reliance, and grit that should not be underestimated [30]. Coming into community engagements with underserved communities, it is important to not only respect but center the resourcefulness of individuals as expertise [25]. Acknowledging these hardships is a step forward, but a more responsible and nuanced approach is to understand that the ingenuity of these individuals is not solely a function of trauma, rather, an inherent characteristic of individuals who are making meaning and building expertise based on their lived experience, similar to ways that academics or those in the tech industry do [62].

5.3 Bidirectional Relationships

Entering the HBAA community as outsiders caused trepidation for some researchers.. As described in 5.1, Martinez encouraged newcomers to be their authentic selves and demonstrate curiosity for the workshop participants. The community check-in circle functioned as an important trust-building mechanism. Within their first hour arriving at HBAA, Google partners sat side-by-side with community participants, sharing their own emotional check-in. Responding to prompts honestly was a way of acknowledging shared humanity and signaling a desire for a truly bidirectional relationship.

Without prompting, this led several of the Google researchers to sit at the workshop tables next to student participants instead of sitting at the front of the classroom or separate from the participants elsewhere in the room. This simple act of sitting together and engaging in the exercises directly with the students built trust and began to foster open informal conversation. Researchers and participants began sharing stories about their own lives. When participants had ideas for how to use AI, the fact that researchers

were there to informally chat about the idea and to encourage further exploration, meant deeper bonds and trust could develop.

Listening with genuine curiosity and a “beginner’s mind” to the ideas being shared was a way of validating their importance to the participants. As a strategy for community engagement, avoiding the thought that some analogous experience gives you privileged access to the new community you are engaging with, helps to foster the curiosity and a true bi-directionality between researcher and participant. Establishing real context for shared exploration means the findings will be richer.

6 CONCLUSION

It is well-known that the development of AI systems is often marred by implicit biases, rooted in broader societal inequalities. This phenomenon stems from a complex interplay of systemic issues. For instance, educational disparities, characterized by unequal opportunities and hostile climates in college-level STEM departments, significantly impede marginalized groups from attaining STEM degrees [45, 50]. Biased hiring practices at large tech companies effectively restrict access to elite internships and job prospects for underrepresented individuals [15]. Compounding these issues is an increasing trend of tech companies capitalizing on marginalized communities as cultural producers, often without meaningful inclusion and agency in the development process itself [7, 21]. These factors collectively shape how historically marginalized communities perceive tech companies - not as partners, but as opportunists. Therefore, authentic connections between the large organization and community-based organizations have to be treated delicately and provide a benefit that the community partner determines for themselves [51]. These relationships need to be formed over time and if a short term engagement is the only viable and feasible option for the corporate technology partner, then engagement should be held through the integration of a community member or other partner who has long standing rapport with the community. Our collaboration aims to shift this paradigm. We strive to 1) create pathways for symbiotic relationships that enhance the self-efficacy of these communities by centering their lived experiences as expertise in the design process, and 2) we seek to seize the opportunity that GenAI, as a general purpose tool presents, to move beyond standard UX design protocols. We recommend establishing protocols for incorporating diverse insights early and iteratively throughout development life-cycles, not just as a path to greater equity, but as a means of creating designs that are more relevant to general users. We argue that outcomes of CBPD more closely reflect society’s needs. By doing so, we can not only address the immediate issue of bias in AI systems and work towards dismantling the systemic barriers that perpetuate inequality in the tech industry, we can simply start building more useful and relevant tech. More inclusive design processes are not just more equitable, they result in building more useful and effective AI technologies that truly serve all segments of society.

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